



“When there was willingness to talk on our part, then where was the need for violence?”

VASUNDHARA RAJE, CHIEF MINISTER, RAJASTHAN

expected the revised input to build up a case for localised ST status. However, following the violence, the state Government is expected to immediately forward to the Centre whatever it has gathered on Gurjars. Bainsla says he won't withdraw unless Government sends its recommendation. “Since every powerful community could grab reservation, we, being poor and deprived, were forced to resort to uncivilised ways to demonstrate our power,” he told INDIA TODAY. However, he has issued an appeal to Gurjars to put an end to violence.

Of the total population of Rajasthan, 12-15 per cent are Jats, 10 per cent Meenas and six per cent are Gurjars. Jats have traditionally cornered 30-40 seats in the 200-seat Assembly and one-third of the 25 parliamentary seats and garner most of the government jobs under quota. They got OBC status in 1999. Meenas were added to the ST list in 1954 and gained sizeable clout in key areas like the police and administration. Gurjars have long been deprived of these benefits. For instance, Meenas have 24 MLAs from reserved seats and seven from the general category in the current Assembly while the Gurjars have just eight.

Social analysts agree that living in similar regions, Gurjars' socio-economic conditions are worse than Meenas. They have a poor sex ratio resulting in polyandry, their unemployed are mostly vagabonds or small-time dacoits and very few get into the services or professional courses. Their concentration is mainly in Swai Madhopur, Karauli, Dholpur, Bharatpur and Dausa district, known as the Dang region. Meenas, who live in the same region, have better awareness about their rights. They are progressive and have a better social standing.

In Rajasthan, if a caste feels better off and secure within any reserved category, it opposes inclusion of any other caste that might threaten their monopoly. So if Jats faced resistance from existing OBCs while attempting entry in

THE GENESIS

■ In Rajasthan's caste-oriented politics, rivalry between Gurjars and Meenas has reached a boiling point.

■ Jats and Meenas have benefitted from OBC and ST status. Jats corner 30-40 seats in the 200-seat Assembly and one third of the 25 parliamentary seats. They garner most of the government jobs under quota. Meenas have big clout in police and administration. Now Gurjars are demanding ST status.

■ An official panel is currently collecting data on Gurjars to see if they can be awarded ST status. Reports suggest that they will not qualify.

QUOTA TOLL: Bodies of Gurjars killed in police firing

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



THE PROBLEMS AHEAD

■ It's now feared that Gurjars' violent agitation could invite similar agitations by Meenas and other upper castes in retaliation.

■ The Meena-Jat-Gurjar rivalry is a serious issue and could have major repercussions if allowed to fester.

■ Discontent has been brewing amongst castes under SC category, which includes as many as 80 sub-castes with varying economic and social status.

■ The dominance of Meenas in the state police force is a cause for worry since excessive use of force against Gurjars has always been a contentious issue.

that category, Gurjars are opposed by Meenas. Off the record, political parties admit to Meenas' political clout and even the need of reservation for Gurjars in certain pockets, but none will admit this in public. A swing in Meena votes away from any party can spell big political trouble. Jats did it to the Congress which opposed their reservation in Rajasthan. Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje, whose daughter-in-law is a Gurjar princess, denies making any promise of ST status for Gurjars, though her rivals say she did so in the last Assembly polls.

For Raje, however, the immediate challenge is to ensure that the current agitation does not get out of hand. She has deputed four ministers for talks with the five persons deputed by the Gurjars. If the talks fail, the Government is ready for curfew as Meenas are mobilising force against Gurjars. One constable killed in Dausa has turned out to be from the Meena community. In fact, last week's violence could well have been avoided. Senior

police officers held a series of meetings, apprehending trouble from the Gurjars, but there was no dialogue with leaders like Bainsla. Also, the heavy presence of Meena officers in police and other services is adding to the problem. At both places, where police resorted to firing, there were Meena officers stationed, fuelling rumours that the firing was deliberate. Gurjar leader Roop Singh Gurjar says postmortem reports have confirmed that all

the dead had bullets fired on their back. “Firing took place at 7:30 a.m. while our agitation was to start at 11 a.m. It shows it was unprovoked,” he says.

The Gurjar agitation proves that it's time to take a fresh look at the reservation policy. “Since every caste and community is demanding reservation, it's time to carry out a census of each caste's population, its economic and social status, grant it points and then work out reservation from villages to national level,” says Satya Narain Singh, former member of Rajasthan Backward Classes Commission and an OBC leader. More than a failure of administration, the violence was a failure of the reservation policy, and the politics that rules it. ■